epiphanies about India, whether on caste identity or gender rights or decentralization of power, felt like college seminars, hardly the shooting-from-the-hip, directly communicative speeches voters could connect to.

Modi's Chai pe Charcha had drawn attention because it was excellently packaged, even if the content was unexceptional. Rahul's town hall-like programmes didn't work because they had neither glossy marketing nor a well-defined message. 'To be honest, we needed to take the battle to the enemy camp. Instead, our leader was still acting like a jholawalla engaged in the discovery of India's poor through group discussions!' is how one frustrated Congressman summed it up for me.

Through March and April, as I travelled around the country for a series of on-the-ground reports, I could see which way the political wind was blowing. In south Bangalore, where former Infosys posterboy Nandan Nilekani was contesting, I met a group of techies. 'We'd love to vote for Nandan, but he is the right man in the wrong party. *Abki Baar Modi Sarkar*!' they shouted in unison.

Already something of an icon among educated youth, Nandan had joined the government in 2009 and initiated the ambitious Aadhar citizen identification project. As a lateral entrant into politics, he offered hope to many private-sector professionals who wanted to shift to public service. In a normal election, Nandan might have had an edge over an Ananth Kumar, a five-time BJP MP accused of doing precious little for the city. But this was no longer a 'normal' election. At Mavalli Tiffin Room (MTR), Bangalore's most famous south Indian eatery, I asked an old man why he was still voting for Ananth Kumar if he was a failed MP. 'This election is about Modi, not Ananth Kumar,' he told me as he poured the ghee over his dosa.

In south Mumbai, Milind Deora was considered a certain winner for the Congress. But I knew he was in trouble when I met an old school friend who said he was going to vote for the Shiv Sena for the first time. 'I strongly disapprove of the Sena's brand of politics, but I want to see Modi as our prime minister,' he rationalized.